



GETTY IMAGES



ANI

**AT THE HELM** (Clockwise from above) JD(U) national president Lalan Singh; RJD Bihar president Jagadanand Singh; Bihar Congress president Akhilesh Prasad Singh

an ironic inversion, the only major party in Bihar that now does not have a 'president' figure from the dominant castes is the BJP—otherwise seen as most favoured by that segment. Its president Sanjay Jaiswal, whose term was supposed to have ended in September 2022, is a Baniya—categorised as an OBC caste group in Bihar. The party's leadership structure makes one nod to its real base, though: its Leader of Opposition, Vijay Sinha, is a Bhumihar.

Paradoxical though it may seem, the logic here is simple. Parties like the RJD and JD(U) can take their solid OBC/ EBC vote banks for granted, while casting their net further afield. The Bhumihars, known as BJP supporters, are about 5-6 per cent of the population—numerically small but cohesive and influential locally. Traditionally Congress supporters till the '90s, the caste elite in Bihar subsequently shifted their allegiance to the BJP. Trying to win them over, therefore, makes eminent sense—it subverts the BJP's base while getting stacked atop their existing bases. (For the BJP, simply reverse the logic.)

A survey conducted in 2011-12 found that elite castes constitute nearly one-fifth of Bihar's population. These include both Hindus (Brahmin, Bhumihar, Rajput, Kayastha) and Muslims (Sheikh, Syed, Pathan). Unlike the divisions among OBC and Dalit voters, given various caste-base claimants like the RJD, JD(U), Lok Janshakti Party (LJP) and the Hindustani Awam Morcha (Secular), these castes are not seen as a divided lot. And the MGB realises the 10 per cent EWS quota has solidified their BJP loyalties. But openings exist into this fortress. One sign came in the 2015 assembly polls when the Congress won 27 seats, with 12 of its 16 dominant caste candidates winning.

The Congress ruled Bihar till the '90s by cobbling together a combination of the elite castes, Dalits and Muslims. With the arrival of Lalu and Nitish, its footprint dwindled sharply. The Dalits and Muslims left it for the RJD and JD(U), and the dominant castes switched to the BJP. Now it seeks to piggyback on Lalu and Nitish for OBC and Muslim votes, while that duo hopes their partnership with the Congress, and their own leaders, can fetch them some votes from the elite castes too. ■